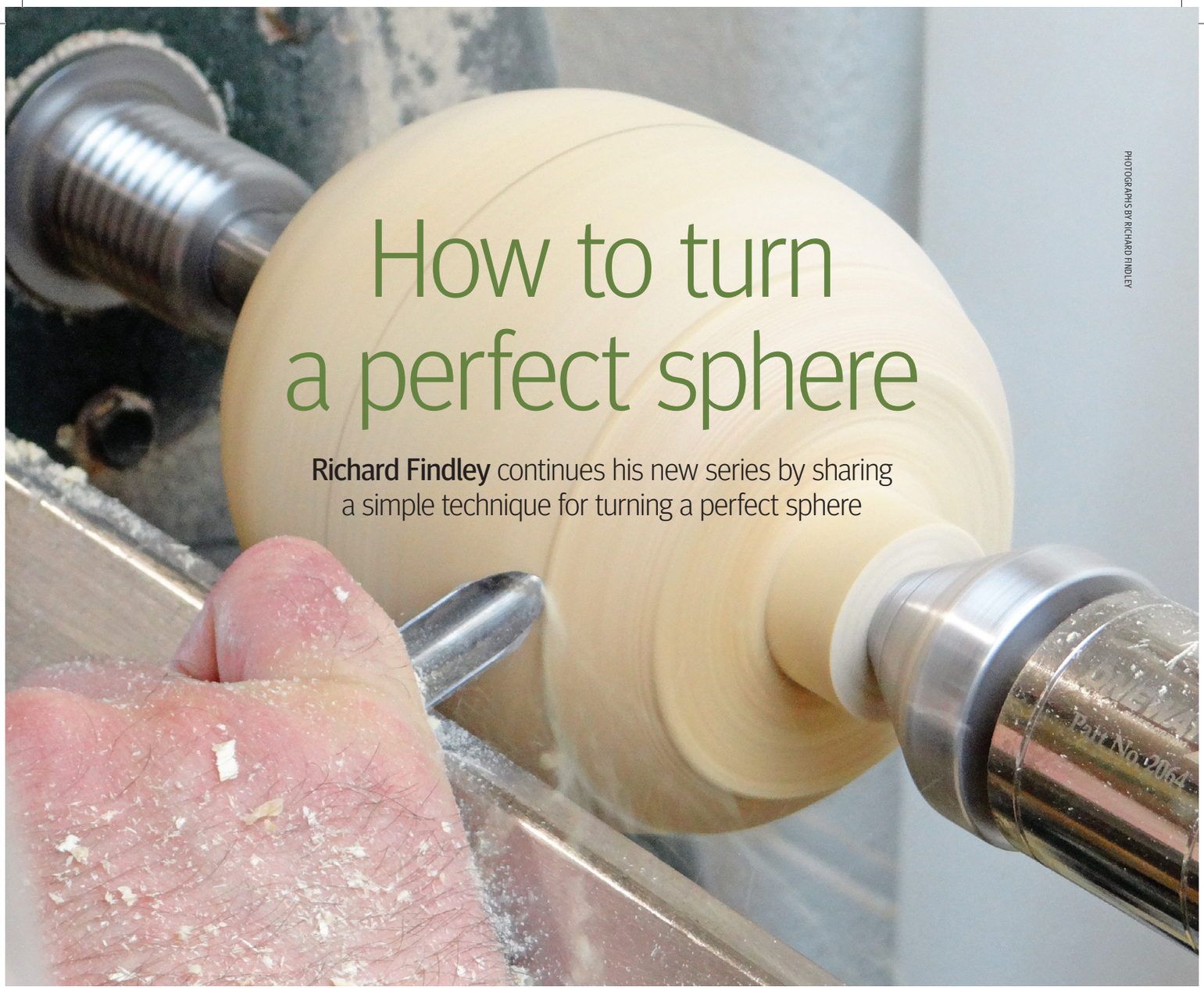

PHOTOGRAPHS BY RICHARD FINDLEY

How to turn a perfect sphere

Richard Findley continues his new series by sharing a simple technique for turning a perfect sphere

RICHARD FINDLEY

Richard is a registered UK professional woodturner living and working in Leicestershire. He discovered woodturning while working for his father as a joiner. He makes all kinds of work to commission, from replacement antique components, walking canes and stair spindles, to decorative bowls. It is the variety of work that he loves. He also offers demonstrations and a range of woodturning supplies.

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Turned wooden spheres hold a certain fascination. They demand to be picked up and rolled in the hand, they show off the figure of the timber and they also hold a mystery to turners and non-turners alike: just how do you turn this perfectly symmetrical shape without marking it?

It's actually not that difficult to do, but there are several stages involved. The method I will show in this article is the simplest way that I have found, but it is by no means the only way. I've seen lots of variations, some involve some very careful marking out, some involve some mathematical formulae or the use of jigs. The beauty of the way I do it is that it is pretty much foolproof!

The blank

The first stage with any turning is sorting out the timber. The spheres I show being turned in this article were for a customer who specified softwood spheres, 110mm in diameter with a 16mm hole drilled through the centre. The hole needed drilling first, but isn't relevant to making a sphere, so I need not go in to any details about that, suffice it to say, the holes make no difference to the making of a sphere.

To achieve 110mm, I laminated two pieces of 65mm European redwood (*Pinus sylvestris*) together, to give me a blank of around 130mm thick, and cut it around 150mm long. The beauty of this project is that you can make your sphere from literally any wood, to any size you like and the technique to create the spheres will be just the same as I show here.

TOP TIP: WASTE WOOD

A common feeling among woodturners and indeed woodworkers of all sorts, is that they hate to waste wood, so will leave as little waste on a blank of timber as possible. The problem with this is that the drive marks at each end penetrate surprisingly deep into the timber, you also need space to work the main shape – in this case the sphere – without the drive centres getting in the way. For any spindle work where you will be parting the work from its driving points, I would always recommend leaving a minimum of 15mm at each end. In this case I've left 20mm at each end. I would always prefer to leave too much waste, rather than not enough!

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